represented a moral risk. Nothing had changed in the material, nothing had changed in our passion to reveal it, but false allegations had been made against me that caused these men to increase their bad behaviour and their stereotyping of me to the point where it was crazy. I might have rescued it, and I certainly tried to do so, but, beyond a certain point, one needs talents I don't have in order to negotiate with people who are that insane with self-interest. They were going to do whatever they wanted to do and I had made several mistakes, the latest of which was to have given them a copy of the cables.

There were some incredible stories in the cables: $25 million worth of bribes to politicians in India, given with the knowledge of apparently sanguine US diplomats; signs of continued American interference in Haitian politics; revelations that a Peruvian presidential candidate had taken money from an alleged drug trafficker; unprecedented levels of lobbying of foreign governments by diplomats on behalf of American corporations; politicians in Lithuania paying journalists for positive coverage; and even spying by American diplomats on their colleagues at the United Nations.

The cables were going to be sensational, but at that point they were not quite ready. Our systems were not yet there with the presentation of the documents, and not ready to cope with the traffic that was bound to follow. We had legal considerations and unresolved sensitivities to do with protecting our source, whoever that was, and this was why I had lodged the material with our partner but demanded an agreement that the material not be published until the green light was clearly given. Any decent publisher would have understood this: it was more important than any scoop that the material be properly ready and that the sources be protected. This was priority number one. But not to the *Guardian*. No sooner had the senior reporter got back to London from his holiday than he began harassing me about publication. He said that a rival journalist, a woman attached to the *Independent*, had a copy of the cables and was a clear threat to their exclusivity.

I investigated that matter. It turned out that our Icelandic colleague, Smári McCarthy, had indeed shared the material with the *Independent* journalist during an anxious moment. He had been asked to work on the cables for a short time to help format them, but, stressed at the workload, he had misguidedly shared them with her – to get some help with the burden of the work involved – under certain strict conditions. He then hacked into the